

1. Defining Democracy

- **Core Definition:** A system where decision-making power lies with the people, either directly or through representatives.
- **Key Principles:** Includes political equality, rule of law, protection of fundamental rights, and leader accountability.
- **Nature:** It is a political culture based on freedom, fairness, and participation, not just a government form.
- **Types of Democracy:**
 - **Direct Democracy:** People vote directly on laws; rare today, mostly found in small communities or referendums.
 - **Representative Democracy:** Citizens elect representatives to decide on their behalf; this is the modern form used in Pakistan.
 - **Social Democracy:** Emphasizes social justice, equal opportunity, and reducing inequality through welfare.

2. The Importance of Social Democracy

- **Concept:** Focuses on social welfare alongside political rights.
- **Requirements:** Voting rights are insufficient without access to education, healthcare, and economic opportunity.
- **Pakistan's Failure:** Democratic failures in Pakistan are linked to the absence of social democracy.
- **Consequences:** Without reducing inequality and empowering marginalized groups, democracy becomes dominated by elites protecting their own interests.
- **Global Context:** Scandinavian examples show democracy flourishes when citizens feel economically secure and trust institutions.

3. Historical Overview: Early Years & Instability (1947–1958)

- **1947–1948 (Jinnah's Era):**
 - Pakistan began with no strong administrative or economic base.
 - Quaid-e-Azam (Governor-General) managed the state despite staff shortages, refugee crises, and the 1947-48 Kashmir war.

- Jinnah emphasized democracy and equality but passed away one year after independence, leaving a political vacuum.
- **1948–1951 (Liaquat Ali Khan):**
 - PM Liaquat Ali Khan passed the **Objectives Resolution (1949)**, establishing Islamic principles and democracy as governance guides.
 - His assassination in 1951 weakened the system and started a cycle of frequent leadership changes.
- **1951–1958 (Era of Instability):**
 - Short-term PMs (Nazimuddin, Bogra, Chaudhry Muhammad Ali, Suhrawardy) could not complete terms due to weak parties and personal rivalries.
 - The Muslim League lost popularity, and regional tensions grew, particularly in East Pakistan regarding representation.
 - Bureaucracy and military gained strength, viewing themselves as "saviors".
 - The **1956 Constitution** made Pakistan an Islamic Republic but failed to resolve provincial autonomy issues or stabilize politics.
 - President Iskander Mirza dismissed multiple PMs and eventually declared Martial Law in October 1958, appointing Ayub Khan as Chief Martial Law Administrator.

4. Military Rule and Political Transitions

- **First Martial Law (1958 – Ayub Khan):**
 - Ayub Khan ousted Mirza, banned parties, and abrogated the constitution, justifying it as a need for "disciplined democracy" against corruption.
 - He introduced the "Basic Democracies" system and the **1962 Constitution**, which concentrated all power in the President.
 - Ayub argued the parliamentary system had failed, but his approach weakened representative democracy.
- **Bhutto Era (1971–1977):**
 - Following the 1971 fall of Dhaka (creation of Bangladesh) and the collapse of Yahya Khan's regime, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto took charge.

- He inherited a broken nation facing economic instability and political bitterness.
- *(Note: The text transitions abruptly to his end)* Bhutto was eventually executed after a controversial trial on conspiracy to murder charges.
- **Zia-ul-Haq Era (1977–1988):**
 - General Zia used Islamization to legitimize his rule and win religious support.
 - **8th Amendment (1985):** Zia held non-party elections and amended the constitution to give the President power to dismiss elected governments, securing his dominance.

5. The "Decade of Democracy" (1988–1999)

- **Overview:** A period of civilian rule marked by fragile democracy and instability following Zia's death.
- **Benazir Bhutto (PPP):**
 - Became the first female PM of a Muslim country in 1988.
 - Her first term faced a hostile President, a powerful military, and opposition from Nawaz Sharif's Punjab government.
 - Dismissed in 1990 by President Ghulam Ishaq Khan for alleged corruption.
 - Returned in 1993 but was dismissed again in 1996 by President Farooq Leghari.
- **Nawaz Sharif (PML-N):**
 - Became PM in 1990 with the IJI coalition (allegedly military-backed).
 - Focused on privatization but clashed with the President/military; dismissed in 1993.
 - Returned in 1997 with a two-thirds majority and passed the **13th Amendment** to strip the President's dismissal power.
 - Confrontations with the judiciary (dismissal of Chief Justice Sajjad Ali Shah) and army (Kargil/nuclear tests context) led to his fall.
- **1999 Coup:** Nawaz's attempt to remove Army Chief Pervez Musharraf backfired, leading to a coup that ended the civilian decade.

6. Reasons for the Failure of Democracy

- **Weak Political Parties:**

- Parties are personality-driven rather than institution-based.
- Lack of internal democracy; leaders are inherited or appointed, not elected.
- Centralized decision-making prevents training new leaders or connecting with the public on policy.
- Parties fracture easily when leaders are removed.

- **Absence of Vibrant Civil Society:**

- Civil society (media, unions, NGOs) is weak, fragmented, and often urban-centric.
- Decades of military rule suppressed independent organizations; unions active in the 50s/60s lost influence.
- Without civil society pressure, elites act with little accountability.

- **Military Interference:**

- Justified by politicians' corruption, but interventions (1958, 1977, 1999) weakened institutions.
- Even during civilian rule, the military retains control over foreign policy and national security.
- Creates a perception that the military is more capable than politicians.

- **Judicialization of Politics:**

- **Doctrine of Necessity:** Courts validated coups and extra-constitutional actions.
- **Judicial Activism:** Courts increasingly shape governance and blur separation of powers.
- **Political Reliance:** Politicians take disputes to court rather than solving them politically, weakening parliamentary supremacy.

7. The Future of Democracy

- **Resilience:** despite setbacks and authoritarian rule, democracy returns, showing it has roots in the political system.

- **Party Reform:** Survival depends on parties democratizing internally and prioritizing public service over personal power.
- **Constitutional Supremacy:**
 - All institutions must operate strictly within constitutional limits.
 - Respect for the constitution prevents instability; violations destroy public trust.
- **Political Tolerance:**
 - Leaders must learn to "agree to disagree" and engage without hostility.
 - Reducing polarization is essential for national stability.
- **Rousseau's Collective Will:**
 - Citizens and leaders must unite around a "general will" for the common good (justice, equality) rather than narrow interests.
 - This transforms democracy from a system of elections into a shared commitment to a fairer society.